

POST INDEPENDENCE DEVELOPMENTS

IDENTITY POLITICS - 1 MODULE-14



CONTEMPORARY DEVELOPMENTS

1 Rise of Coalition governments - Won only 197 seats in the election - marked the end of the Congress system. Continued to rule but lost centrality.

2 Mandal politics - National Front government decided to implement the recommendation of the Mandal Commission in 1990- reserve seats for Other Backwards Classes Central government jobs. Violent protests between supporters and opponents

3 New Economic policy initiated by PM Rajiv Gandhi - changed the course of the Indian economy.

4 Events leading to demolition of Bari Masjid in December 1992- leading to debates on Indian nationalism and secularism. It led to rise of BJP and politics of 'Hindutva'.

5 Rajiv Gandhi was assassinated in 1991 by the Sri Lankan Tamil linked to LTTE. Rajiv Gandhi was succeeded by P.V. Narsimha Rao



RISE OF COALITION GOVERNMENTS

- 1** **Multi-party governments** - After defeat of Congress in 1989, no other party won majority to form government.
 - National Front- Janata dal+ regional parties- was supported by BJP and Left Front from outside. This led to the rise of coalition governments.
- 2** In 1996, United Front government came to power with support from Congress as an anti-BJP alliance
- 3** From May 1998 to June 1999 and in October 1999, coalition governments were formed.
- 4** End of Congress dominance- Congress was not a coalition of different interests and social strata. Several sections leaving Congress and forming political parties weakened Congress party.
- 5** Emergence of parties and movements representing Dalit and Other Backward Classes- regional assertion. They played an important role in the United Front government



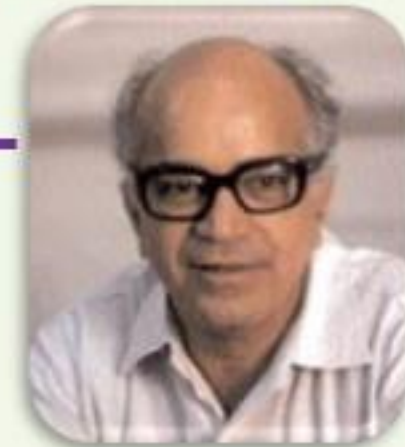
CASTE-BASED POLITICS



*"In India you do not cast your vote;
you vote your caste"*

- V. N. Gadgil

Congress politician, 1995



- The most striking feature of Indian politics in the 1960s and 70s was the rise of the 'backward castes', of those groups intermediate between the Scheduled Castes at the bottom and the Brahmins and Rajputs at the top.
- Yadavs in UP and Bihar, Jats in Punjab and Haryana, Marathas in Maharashtra, Vokkaligas in Karnataka and Gounders in Tamil Nadu.

OTHER BACKWARD CASTES

- 1** In Indian law these groups are known as the Other Backward Castes (or Classes), to distinguish them from the Scheduled Tribes and Scheduled Castes.
- 2** It was these OBCs who formed the social base and provided the leadership of the parties that successfully challenged the dominance of the Congress Party.
- 3** Economic power had come to the OBCs through land reforms and the Green Revolution; political power through the ballot box.



What was lacking was administrative power

MANDAL COMMISSION

- 1 In Bihar, Karpoori Thakur introduced a policy for reservations and government appointed the Second Backward Classes Commission or Mandal Commission to identify ways to improve the condition of the Backward Classes.
- 2 It was thus that the Janata government had appointed the Backward Classes Commission, known then, and ever after, as the Mandal Commission after its proactive chairman.
- 3 The Commission concluded that caste was still the main indicator of 'backwardness'.
- 4 It identified, on the basis of state surveys, as many as 3,743 specific castes which were still backward.
- 5 These castes were very poorly represented in the administration, especially at the higher levels.
- 6 To redress this anomaly, the Mandal Commission recommended that 27 per cent of all posts in central government be reserved for these castes, to add to the 22.5 per cent already set apart for Scheduled Castes and Tribes.

MANDAL COMMISSION



OBJECTIVE OF MANDAL COMMISSION

- ✓ Investigate the extent of educational and social backwardness among various sections of Indian society;
- ✓ Recommend ways of identification of people falling within this category;
- ✓ Suggest ways to end the backwardness.



MANDAL COMMISSION

- 1 Commission gave its recommendations in 1980.
- 2 'Backwards classes' should be understood as 'Backward castes' as many castes were regarded inferior in the caste hierarchy.
- 3 Identified that Backward castes had very low presence in educational institutions and employment in public services.
- 4 It recommended reserving 27 percent seats in educational institutions and government jobs.
- 5 Other recommendations include land reform, improving conditions of OBCs.

In August 1990, the National Front government decided to implement reservations for OBCs in jobs in the central government. This decision was challenged by the Supreme Court in the 'Indira Sawhney Case'. Besides differences in the method of implementation, all political parties supported reservations for OBCs.



INDIRA SAWHNEY

RESERVATIONS FOR BACKWARD CLASSES

- 1 When a National Front government came to power after the general election of 1989, the report was disinterred.
- 2 The new Prime Minister, V. P. Singh, was sensible of the rising political power of the OBCs, and of his less-than-solid position as head of a minority coalition.
- 3 On 13 August, a government order was issued to implement the basic recommendation of the Mandal report.

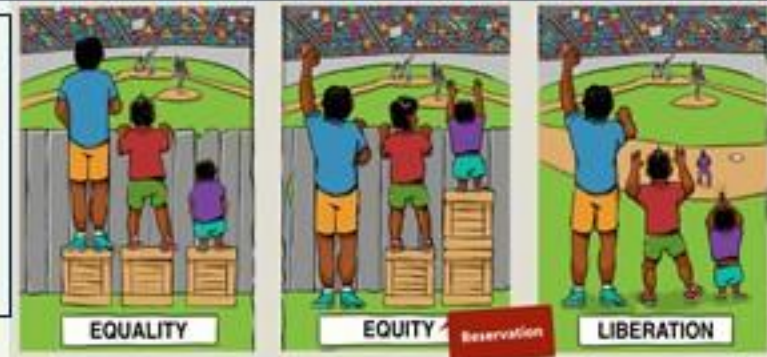


B. P. MANDAL

Henceforth, 27 per cent of all vacancies in the government of India would be reserved for candidates from the 'socially and educationally backward classes identified by the Commission.

DEBATES AROUND RESERVATIONS

- 1 The order sparked a lively debate in intellectual circles.
- 2 Some scholars argued that the criteria for job reservation should be family income, rather than membership of a particular caste.
- 3 Others deplored the extension of affirmative action in the first place; by allocating one job in two on considerations other than merit, the efficacy and reliability of public institutions was being put at risk.
- 4 However, there were also scholars who welcomed the implementation of the Mandal recommendations as a corrective to the dominance of upper castes, and especially Brahmins, in the public services.
- 5 They pointed to the states of south India, where more than two-thirds of government jobs were allocated on the basis of caste, without (it was argued) affecting the efficiency of the administration.



JUDICIAL RULING

1 In September 1990, a case was brought before the Supreme Court of India, contesting the constitutional validity of the Mandal Commission's recommendations.

2 Three principal arguments were made by the petitioner:

- That the extension of reservation violated the constitutional guarantee of equality of opportunity;
- That caste was not a reliable indicator of backwardness; and
- That the efficiency of public institutions was at risk.

3 The Supreme Court finally gave its verdict on 16 November 1992.

4 In upholding the government orders, the Supreme Court added two caveats:

- That reservations should not exceed 50 per cent of the jobs in government
- Caste criteria would apply only in recruitment, not in promotions.



VARIATIONS IN NORTH VERSUS SOUTH

The conflicts sparked by the Mandal Commission recommendations were far more intense in northern India.

- 1 For one thing, affirmative action programmes had long been in existence in the south.
- 2 For another, that region also had a thriving industrial sector; thus educated young men were no longer as dependent on government employment.
- 3 Again, while in the south the upper castes constituted less than 10 per cent of the population, the figure in the north was in excess of 20 per cent.



IMPACT OF MANDAL COMMISSION

- 1** The influence exercised by the States Reorganization Commission was direct: it led to the redrawing of the administrative map of India on linguistic lines.
- 2** The Mandal Commission's influence, however, was mostly indirect. By its terms only a few thousand government jobs came up for allotment to OBCs.
- 3** But the debate the Report sparked, and its eventual acceptance, provided a tremendous fillip to OBC pride and solidarity.
- 4** Among the beneficiaries were the two Yadavs, Lalu and Mulayam. Both left the Janata Dal and setup their own parties, and very successfully too.

RESERVATION CATEGORY	RESERVATION QUOTA (%)
ST	7.5
SC	15
OBC	27
EWS	10
Total	59.50%



LALU AND MULAYAM

DALIT IDENTITY

1 The 1990s also witnessed an upsurge by Dalits, as the former Untouchable castes were now known.

2 This was led by the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), which was founded by Kanshi Ram.

3 Before Kanshi Ram, Jagjivan Ram had 'carried the banner of the downtrodden and stood for their interests'. He died in 1988.



JAGJIVAN RAM



KANSHI RAM

BAHUJAN SAMAJ PARTY

- 1** In 1971, Kanshi Ram formed an organization to represent government employees from a disadvantaged background. This was called the All-India Backward and Minority Communities Employees Federation (BAMCEF).
- 2** It was a trade union of the Scheduled Caste elite, which, in the leader's words, would form the 'think tank', 'talent bank' and 'financial bank' for the depressed classes as a whole.
- 3** BAMCEF's growth area was north India, particularly Uttar Pradesh.
- 4** The organization's success emboldened Kanshi Ram to start a political party. It came to be called the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), 'Bahujan' being a more inclusive category than 'Dalit'.
- 5** Whereas the latter represented the Scheduled Castes or former Untouchables, the former contained within it backward castes and Muslims as well came to be better represented at the higher levels, working as Class I magistrates and officers in the secretariat.



CONSCIOUS DALIT COMMUNITY

1 A government job provided both economic security and social prestige. The BSP won eleven seats in 1996 and fourteen seats in 1999.

2 By 2000, it was garnering a steady 20 per cent of the popular vote. The BSP's gains were mostly at the expense of the Congress.

3 Once submissive as well as suppressed, the Dalits now knew of their rights under the Indian Constitution, and were prepared to fight for them.



DALITS IN WEST BENGAL

- 1 In West Bengal, these inequalities had been attenuated by land reforms.
- 2 The middle and upper castes owned the land, and the Dalits tilled it.
- 3 From the 1970s, however, Maoist radicals had taken up their case. Although they had more or less disappeared from West Bengal, where their movement had begun a decade previously, these Naxalites had steadily gathered strength in the districts of central Bihar.
- 4 They formed agricultural labour fronts which demanded higher wages, shorter hours and an end to social coercion (which, in some areas, included the right of the landlord to a low-caste bride on her wedding night).
- 5 They also demanded a share of village common land, and access to natural resources such as fresh-water fish, theoretically owned by the 'community' as a whole, but usually the preserve of the upper castes alone.
- 6 Their mobilization by left-wing radicals had instilled a great deal of self-respect among the lowliest in central Bihar.

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